

STRUCTURAL TRANSFORMATION OF ELECTORAL POLITICS IN UTTAR PRADESH (2002–2022):

An Integrated Institutional and Econometric Analysis



**Department of Humanities and Social Sciences
Indian Institute of Technology, Kharagpur**

2025

STRUCTURAL TRANSFORMATION OF ELECTORAL POLITICS IN UTTAR PRADESH (2002–2022):

An Integrated Institutional and Econometric Analysis

A Report Submitted for the Course

Primary Research Lab (EM69207)

by

Dhruv Singh (22HS23004)

Parikh Ansh Ashokkumar (22HS23012)

Sohail Belim (22HS23015)

Ujjawal Prasad (22HS23020)

Amitesh Kumar (22HS3AI24)

Sarthak Jain (22HS3AI26)



**Department of Humanities and Social Sciences
Indian Institute of Technology, Kharagpur**

2025

Contents

1	INTRODUCTION	1
1.1	The Democratic Paradox of Uttar Pradesh	1
1.2	The Research Puzzle: Limitations of the Median Voter Theorem	2
1.3	Objectives and Research Questions	3
1.4	Theoretical Framework: An Institutional Approach	3
1.5	Methodological Innovations	4
1.6	Roadmap of the Report	5
2	LITERATURE REVIEW AND CONTEXT	7
2.1	The Historical Arc of Uttar Pradesh Politics	7
2.2	The Collapse of the “Congress System” (1952–1989)	8
2.3	The “Mandal Era”: Competitive Clientelism and Instability (1989–2012)	8
2.4	The Failure of the Median Voter Theorem in UP	9
2.5	The BJP’s Resurgence: “Post-Mandal” Engineering	10
2.6	Identifying the Gap: The Need for Structural Analysis	10
3	THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK	12
3.1	The Institutional Logic of Political Transitions	12
3.2	Adapting the Model to Uttar Pradesh: From Class to Caste	13
3.3	The Mechanism of Instability (2002–2012): The Unaligned Middle	14
3.4	The Mechanism of Consolidation (2014–2022): The Conservative Compact	14
3.5	Hypotheses for Empirical Testing	15
4	ECONOMETRIC FRAMEWORK AND STATISTICAL SPECIFICATIONS	17
4.1	Beyond Ordinary Least Squares: The Need for Advanced Modeling	17
4.2	Modeling Bounded Preferences: The GLM Fractional Logit Model	18
4.3	Capturing Heterogeneity: Quantile Regression	18
4.4	Isolating Structural Depth: Hierarchical Mixed-Effects Model (HLM)	19

4.5	Testing Counter-Polarization: The Quadratic Interaction Model	20
4.6	Tracing Vote Sources: The “Cannibalization” Test	20
4.7	Determining Timing: The Event Study	21
5	DATA, VARIABLES, AND METHODOLOGY	22
5.1	Data Architecture and Sources	22
5.2	Variable Engineering	23
5.3	Econometric Strategy	24
5.3.1	GLM Fractional Logit (Quasi-MLE)	24
5.3.2	Quantile Regression	24
5.3.3	Non-Linear Quadratic Specification	24
5.3.4	Hierarchical Mixed-Effects Model (HLM)	25
5.3.5	The “Cannibalization” Test and Event Study	25
5.4	Analytical Phases	25
6	RESULTS AND DISCUSSION	26
6.1	Overview: The Empirical Verification of Hegemony	26
6.2	The Middle Class Pivot: The Non-Yadav OBC Realignment	27
6.2.1	GLM Fractional Logit Results	27
6.2.2	The Structural Break (Event Study)	28
6.2.3	Quantile Regression: The Strategy of Expansion	30
6.3	The “Cannibalization” of the Samajwadi Party	32
6.4	The Fragmentation of the Dalit Vote: Co-opting the Non-Jatavs	34
6.5	The Counter-Polarization Mechanism: The “U-Curve”	34
6.6	Institutional Depth: The Role of District Culture	36
6.7	Summary of Findings	37
7	CONCLUSION AND POLICY IMPLICATIONS	39
7.1	The New Architecture of Power	39
7.2	Theoretical Contributions	40
7.3	Future Projections: Is the Equilibrium Durable?	40
7.4	Policy Implications for Indian Democracy	41
8	REFERENCES	42

Chapter 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 The Democratic Paradox of Uttar Pradesh

Uttar Pradesh (UP) occupies a distinctive place within the Indian Union. With a population exceeding 230 million, it would rank as the fifth most populous country in the world if it were an independent nation. In discussions about democracy, UP therefore functions as a crucial testing ground: it is a state in which electoral politics must operate under conditions of intense social diversity, deep economic inequality, and entrenched caste hierarchies.

For several decades, political scientists have tended to describe UP using the lens of “competitive fragmentation.” In this view, power shifts among unstable coalitions of caste-based parties, and this constant churn prevents any single party or alliance from entrenching long-term dominance. What we see is not a unified, median voter but a patchwork of social blocs, each negotiating for access to state resources.

Yet the political history of UP between 2002 and 2022 complicates this stylized picture. Over these two decades, the state appears to move between two very different political equilibria. The first, roughly from 2002 to 2012, is characterized by multipolar competition. In this phase, parties mobilize voters primarily along caste lines: Dalits rally behind the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), Yadavs line up behind the Samajwadi Party (SP), and national parties like the Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) often play a secondary role. The electorate, in other words, is fractured into distinct caste-anchored camps.

The second phase begins around 2014 and consolidates through the 2017 and 2022 elections. Here, the state shifts towards what looks like unipolar hegemony. The BJP does more than simply win elections—it reshapes the electoral marketplace itself. By securing back-to-back majorities in both the Lok Sabha (2014, 2019) and the UP Vidhan Sabha (2017, 2022), the party achieves something that earlier commentators on post-Mandal politics considered highly unlikely: it forges a cross-caste Hindu majority that bridges the historical divide between Upper Castes and Other Backward Classes (OBCs).

This report is an attempt to make sense of that transformation. It argues that the BJP’s

rise in UP cannot be fully explained by campaign strategy or the personal popularity of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, although both clearly matter. Instead, the central claim is that the state has undergone a deeper institutional realignment of class and caste forces. Using the theoretical framework developed by Acemoglu and Robinson (2006), and combining it with constituency-level econometric analysis, the study argues that UP has moved from an unstable redistributive contest to a relatively durable “Conservative Democratic Equilibrium.”

1.2 The Research Puzzle: Limitations of the Median Voter Theorem

The key theoretical puzzle that motivates this study is the disconnect between standard political economy models and the empirical trajectory of UP. The Median Voter Theorem (MVT), which sits at the heart of much democratic theory, predicts that in a country where most voters are poor, parties will converge on redistributive economic platforms in order to capture the median voter. In principle, a poor state like UP—with high levels of inequality, agrarian distress, and weak public services—should be fertile ground for a stable, pro-poor coalition demanding structural redistribution, including land reform, progressive taxation, and universal welfare.

In practice, something very different happened. Instead of aligning along economic lines, poor voters in UP fragmented along axes of identity.

- **Dalit voters**, especially the Jatav sub-caste, placed dignity and representation at the centre of their politics, and gravitated towards the BSP as a vehicle of social assertion.
- **Yadav voters**, a dominant landed OBC group, focused on agrarian control and local administrative power and rallied behind the SP.
- **Pasmanda Muslim voters** prioritized physical security and protection from communal violence.
- **Non-Yadav OBC voters**, drawn from artisanal and lower-peasant castes, sought upward mobility but often feared Yadav dominance more than Upper Caste dominance.

The result was a “multi-peaked” preference structure. A typical voter’s utility in UP cannot be captured simply by income, U_{income} . Instead, it reflects a weighted combination of identity (U_{identity}), physical security (U_{security}), and relative caste status (U_{status}).

This leads to a sharper version of the research question: **How did the BJP, historically seen as an Upper Caste–dominated party rooted in urban Brahmin–Bania networks, manage to draw support from lower-OBC and Dalit voters without offering the kind of structural redistribution that standard models would predict?**

Answering this question requires moving beyond aggregate vote-share statistics. It requires looking at how the BJP built a new “Elite–Middle” coalition that circumvented the conventional “Elite vs. Poor” conflict assumed in much of the political economy literature.

1.3 Objectives and Research Questions

The broader goal of this report is to identify and empirically validate the mechanisms that underpin this political realignment. Rather than relying on journalistic language about “caste chemistry,” it treats the realignment as a set of testable hypotheses, evaluated using constituency-level data over a twenty-year period.

The analysis is organized around three central research questions:

1. **The Question of Instability:** What structural conditions made the pre-2014 democratic equilibrium unstable? Why were the SP and BSP unable to retain the loyalty of Non-Yadav OBCs, despite appealing to a shared language of “social justice”?
2. **The Question of Coalition Construction:** How did the BJP assemble a durable **Elite–Middle Class coalition** after 2014? Through what mechanisms did it reconcile the interests of Upper Castes, who tend to favour the status quo, with those of Non-Yadav OBCs, who seek upward mobility?
3. **The Question of Demographic Mechanics:** What does the constituency-level data actually show about the behaviour of different caste and religious sub-groups? Has the idea of a “Muslim Veto” lost its relevance? Have Dalits as a whole moved closer to the BJP, or are shifts concentrated in particular sub-castes?

1.4 Theoretical Framework: An Institutional Approach

To answer these questions, the report adapts the institutional framework developed by Daron Acemoglu and James A. Robinson in *Economic Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy*. Although their model is usually applied to explain transitions between authoritarian and democratic regimes, it can also be repurposed to understand shifts

within democracies, especially changes in the coalitions that stabilize different types of democratic equilibria.

In this adaptation, the UP electorate is divided into three broad A&R-style categories:

- **The Elite:** Groups with high status and concentrated resources. In UP, this category maps onto **Upper Castes** (Brahmins, Thakurs, Vaishyas).
- **The Middle Class:** Numerically significant, upwardly mobile groups with moderate assets. This role is played by the **Non-Yadav OBCs** (Kurmis, Lodhs, Kushwahas, Mauryas, and others).
- **The Poor:** Low-income groups with strong redistributive preferences. In UP, this category primarily includes **Dalits and Muslims**.

The central theoretical claim is that the stability of UP's democratic order depends on how the **Middle Class (Non-Yadav OBCs)** align.

- In the 2002–2012 period, this group was dispersed across multiple parties, and its lack of coordination contributed to persistent instability.
- After 2014, the BJP appears to have detached the Middle from the Poor and aligned it with the Elite. The outcome is a **Conservative Democratic Equilibrium**: a numerically viable coalition that can reliably win elections while resisting far-reaching redistributive reforms that might threaten Elite interests.

1.5 Methodological Innovations

A key feature of this report is that it treats the above claims as hypotheses to be evaluated rigorously, rather than as descriptive narratives. It does so by using a suite of econometric tools applied to a comprehensive dataset of UP Assembly elections spanning 2002 to 2022.

The main methodological components are:

- **GLM Fractional Logit Models:** Instead of relying on ordinary least squares (OLS), which can produce illogical predictions (such as negative or above-100% vote shares), the analysis uses fractional logit models (Quasi-MLE) that are better suited for bounded outcomes like vote shares.

- **Quantile Regression:** Because demographic effects may look different in “safe” versus “swing” constituencies, quantile regression is used to capture how these effects vary across the distribution of BJP vote share.
- **Hierarchical Mixed-Effects Models:** Recognizing that constituencies are nested within districts, the analysis employs mixed-effects models to estimate the Intra-Class Correlation (ICC), which helps separate the influence of demographic composition from that of district-level political cultures and organizational strength.
- **Non-Linear Quadratic Specifications:** The “Counter-Polarization” hypothesis—the idea that Hindu consolidation intensifies non-linearly as the Muslim share of the population rises—is tested by introducing quadratic terms for Muslim population density.
- **Event Study Analysis:** To determine whether the realignment occurred gradually or abruptly, the report uses an event-study framework that tracks changes in key coefficients across multiple election cycles and identifies the structural break associated with the 2014 shift.

1.6 Roadmap of the Report

The remainder of the report is structured as follows:

- **Chapter 2: Literature Review** surveys the existing scholarship on UP politics, from the “Congress System” to the “Mandal Era,” and identifies the specific gaps this study addresses.
- **Chapter 3: Theoretical Framework** develops the Acemoglu–Robinson-inspired model in greater detail and adapts it to UP’s caste geography, with a focus on coalition formation.
- **Chapter 4: Data and Methodology** explains how the dataset was constructed, how key variables were defined and transformed, and why particular econometric specifications were chosen.
- **Chapter 5: Results and Discussion** presents the empirical findings, including patterns in Dalit, OBC, and Muslim voting, the shape of the “Counter-Polarization” curve, and evidence of the “Cannibalization” of the Samajwadi Party’s base.
- **Chapter 6: Conclusion** synthesizes the empirical and theoretical insights, characterizes the contours of UP’s new hegemonic order, and reflects on its broader implications for Indian democracy.

By combining detailed quantitative analysis with a clear institutional framework, the report seeks to offer a coherent account of how a state once emblematic of fragmented politics has become one of the BJP's strongest bastions.

Chapter 2

LITERATURE REVIEW AND CONTEXT

2.1 The Historical Arc of Uttar Pradesh Politics

To understand the scale of the BJP’s post-2014 consolidation in Uttar Pradesh, it is useful to situate it within a longer historical trajectory. Scholars typically divide UP’s post-independence political history into three broad structural phases: the period of **Congress Dominance** (1952–1989), the era of **Mandal-Dalit Fragmentation** (1989–2014), and the current phase of **Hindutva Hegemony** (2014–present).

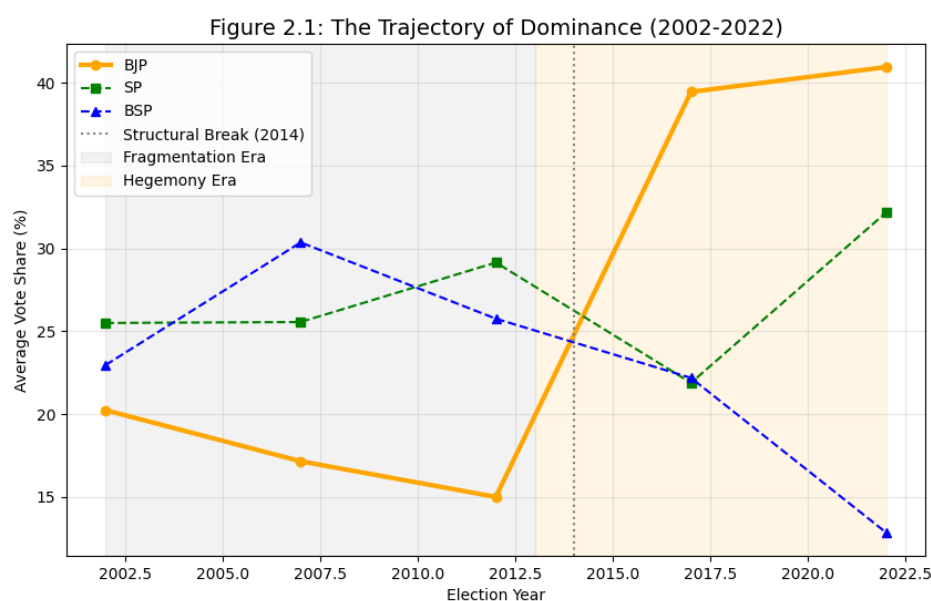


Figure 2.1: The Trajectory of Dominance (2002–2022)

This chapter reviews the literature on these transitions, with a particular focus on why the “Mandal” era of caste-based parties—expected by many to empower the numerical majority—struggled to produce a stable democratic equilibrium.

2.2 The Collapse of the “Congress System” (1952–1989)

For the first four decades after independence, UP functioned as one of the strongest bastions of the Indian National Congress. Rajni Kothari famously conceptualized this as the “Congress System,” a form of one-party dominance in which Congress operated as an umbrella organization integrating a wide spectrum of interests. In UP, this rested on a “Rainbow Coalition” that brought together **Upper Castes** (particularly Brahmins), **Dalits**, and **Muslims**.

This arrangement was relatively stable for a time because it combined the resources and social legitimacy of elite groups (Upper Castes) with the numerical weight of marginalized communities (Dalits and Muslims). Yet, as Paul Brass (1985) and others noted, this system operated through a hierarchical patronage network. Dalits and Muslims were incorporated primarily as “vote banks” mediated by Upper Caste intermediaries, rather than as empowered political actors in their own right.

The erosion of this system in the late 1980s is often linked to the socio-economic changes of the Green Revolution. Intermediate agrarian castes—Yadavs, Kurmis, Jats, and others—gained economic strength but remained politically marginalized within the Brahmin-dominated Congress structure. Their assertion helped undermine the Congress System, giving rise first to the Janata Dal and later to its regional successors, especially the Samajwadi Party (SP). At the same time, Dalits, mobilized by Kanshi Ram and Mayawati, broke away from Congress patronage and coalesced under the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), which promised autonomous representation.

2.3 The “Mandal Era”: Competitive Clientelism and Instability (1989–2012)

The period from 1989 to 2012 is usually understood as the “Mandal Era,” marked by the rise of caste-based parties and a more explicitly competitive form of identity politics. Scholars such as Kanchan Chandra (*Why Ethnic Parties Succeed*, 2004) and Christophe Jaffrelot (*India’s Silent Revolution*, 2003) describe this phase as one of “patronage democracy” or “ethnic headcounting,” in which parties seek to mobilize specific caste blocs and distribute benefits accordingly.

In UP, two parties came to dominate this landscape:

- The **Samajwadi Party (SP)** emerged as the principal vehicle for Yadavs and Muslims.

- The **Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP)** became the core representative of Dalits, particularly the Jatav/Chamar community.

While this architecture did succeed in bringing historically marginalized groups into the centre of political competition, it also introduced a deep form of instability. One key reason, highlighted by Sudha Pai (2002) and A.K. Verma (2014), was the internal fragmentation of the OBC category. In rhetoric, the SP claimed to represent all Backward Classes; in practice, the distribution of positions, contracts, and administrative posts often skewed heavily towards Yadavs.

This process, sometimes described as the “Yadavization” of power, alienated **Non-Yadav OBCs**—the group that this report treats as the “Middle Class” in the Acemoglu–Robinson framework. Castes such as Kurmis, Lodhs, Shakyas, and Mauryas were culturally distinct from Upper Castes but socially and economically in competition with dominant Yadavs. With no party articulating their specific interests, their votes tended to swing between the BJP, BSP, SP, and smaller outfits, contributing to the electoral volatility observed in the 2002, 2007, and 2012 elections.

2.4 The Failure of the Median Voter Theorem in UP

Much of the political economy literature on India grapples with what might be called the “Redistribution Puzzle.” The Median Voter Theorem suggests that in poorer democracies, parties should compete by offering broad-based public goods—education, healthcare, infrastructure—to a largely poor electorate.

However, despite intense competition, public goods provision in UP has historically remained poor. Keefer and Khemani (2005) argue that when voters are polarized along ethnic or caste lines, politicians have weaker incentives to provide universal public goods. Instead, they prioritize “club goods” targeted at their core support groups.

In UP, this logic played out clearly:

- Under SP governments, improvements in electricity supply or policing were often noted in Yadav-dominated villages, while other areas lagged.
- Under BSP governments, attention and resources flowed disproportionately to Ambedkar villages and Dalit habitations.

The broader implication is that **the poor in UP never cohered into a unified redistributive bloc** because internal social conflicts—especially Dalit–OBC tensions—overrode shared economic interests. The “Dalit versus OBC” conflict, often violent in rural settings,

undermined the possibility of a broad pro-poor coalition. This, in turn, left the field open for a different kind of consolidation.

2.5 The BJP's Resurgence: "Post-Mandal" Engineering

The literature on the BJP's resurgence in UP after 2014, including works by Nalin Mehta (*The New BJP*, 2022) and Prashant Jha (*How the BJP Wins*, 2017), marks a shift from analyzing caste fragmentation to examining "Hindutva consolidation." This body of work identifies several mechanisms that allowed the BJP to cut through the stalemate of the Mandal era.

Three stand out in particular:

1. **Subaltern Hindutva:** The BJP promoted leaders from non-dominant OBC and Dalit castes (for example, Keshav Prasad Maurya), and gave them visibility and organizational responsibility. This signalled to Non-Yadav OBCs and Non-Jatav Dalits that they could achieve representation within the BJP in a way they never fully could in the SP or BSP.
2. **Labharthi (Beneficiary) Politics:** Welfare schemes such as subsidized LPG connections, housing, and toilets created a direct link between the state and the voter, bypassing local caste intermediaries. This "bypassing" weakened the older patronage networks that had sustained SP and BSP.
3. **The "Muslim Veto" Narrative:** By appealing to a broad Hindu identity (Upper Castes + Non-Yadav OBCs + sections of Non-Jatav Dalits), the BJP effectively turned UP's demographic arithmetic on its head. The Muslim vote—around 19% of the population—was portrayed as something that could be neutralized through Hindu consolidation, making it less relevant in determining electoral outcomes.

2.6 Identifying the Gap: The Need for Structural Analysis

While this literature has done a good job of describing the BJP's strategies and documenting its rise, it is often either narrative or based on simple, descriptive statistics. There remains a shortage of work that:

- **Quantifies** the scale and direction of the Non-Yadav OBC shift using rigorous econometric tools.

- **Tests** the “Counter-Polarization” hypothesis with formal models rather than treating it as an impressionistic observation.
- **Links** these empirical patterns back to a formal institutional framework, such as that of Acemoglu and Robinson.

Many accounts still describe the BJP’s rise as a “wave” of nationalism or charisma. This report instead treats it as a **structural realignment of class forces**. By embedding the analysis in the Acemoglu–Robinson framework, it argues that the BJP’s success lies less in changing voter sentiment in the abstract and more in solving the long-standing collective action problem of the “Middle Class” (Non-Yadav OBCs). The following chapters lay out this framework in more detail and then subject it to empirical testing.

Chapter 3

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

3.1 The Institutional Logic of Political Transitions

To move beyond surface-level explanations centred on electoral waves or charismatic leaders, this study turns to the institutional framework developed by Daron Acemoglu and James A. Robinson (A&R) in *Economic Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy* (2006). Although the framework is usually deployed to explain transitions between autocracy and democracy, its logic can also help us understand shifts *within* democratic regimes—specifically, how coalitions form and why they remain stable or fall apart.

The A&R framework is built on a stylized three-class model:

- **The Elite (E):** A minority that holds a disproportionate share of wealth and power. This group generally prefers low taxation, limited redistribution, and social order.
- **The Middle Class (M):** A buffer group with moderate assets and aspirations for upward mobility. Crucially, this group can ally either with the Elite or with the Poor.
- **The Poor (P):** The majority with low incomes and a strong preference for redistribution and structural reforms.

A&R's key insight is that the stability of any democratic arrangement depends on where the Middle Class chooses to align.

- **Scenario A (Redistributive Instability):** If the Middle aligns with the Poor ($M+P$), they form a strong coalition that can push through significant redistribution at the expense of the Elite. The Elite, fearing expropriation, may seek to undermine democratic institutions, leading to instability or regression.
- **Scenario B (Conservative Equilibrium):** If the Middle aligns with the Elite ($M+E$), the resulting coalition moderates redistributive pressures. The Elite's core interests are protected, and the Middle receives some benefits in return (status, policy concessions, or targeted welfare). With the Poor marginalized, the Elite no longer fear democracy, and the system becomes more stable.

3.2 Adapting the Model to Uttar Pradesh: From Class to Caste

Translating this economic model to the context of UP requires careful attention to how caste and class overlap. While caste is not a perfect proxy for economic class, the association is strong enough in UP to construct a plausible mapping.

1. The Elite $\approx$ Upper Castes (Brahmins, Thakurs, Vaishyas)

Demographic Weight: roughly 18–20%

Interests: Historically, the landed gentry and urban professional classes. They lost political pre-eminence during the Mandal era and sought ways to reassert influence. They are generally wary of aggressive affirmative action and radical land reforms that might erode their position.

2. The Middle Class $\approx$ Non-Yadav OBCs (Kurmis, Lodhs, Mauryas, Kushwahas, etc.)

Demographic Weight: roughly 30–35%

Interests: An aspiring agrarian and artisanal stratum with moderate assets and strong upward mobility aspirations. They experience a “dual anxiety”: historical subordination to Upper Castes on the one hand, and immediate competition with dominant Yadavs and assertive Dalits on the other.

In this framework, the term ‘Middle Class’ refers to structural position rather than pure economic income. While many Non-Yadav OBCs remain economically vulnerable, they function as the ‘Middle’ because they possess distinct aspirational characteristics that separate them from the ‘Poor’ (Dalits). Unlike the landless Dalit base, these groups often hold small agrarian assets or artisanal skills. Their political behavior is driven by ‘status anxiety’—the fear of falling into the Dalit stratum and the desire to rise to Elite status—making them the pivotal swing group in the Acemoglu-Robinson model.

3. The Poor/Excluded $\approx$ Dalits, Muslims, and Yadavs

Demographic Weight: roughly 45–50%

Interests:

- **Dalits (especially Jatavs):** Seek protection from social oppression and access to state resources (core BSP base).
- **Muslims:** Prioritize physical security and protection from majoritarian violence (core SP base in coalition with Yadavs).

- **Yadavs:** Economically better off than Dalits, but often positioned as the “hostile” agrarian bloc in competition with Non-Yadav OBCs.

3.3 The Mechanism of Instability (2002–2012): The Unaligned Middle

In the 2002–2012 period, the Middle Class in this framework—the Non-Yadav OBCs—did not cohere around a single political option. Instead, they were scattered across parties:

- Some joined the **SP**, but often felt overshadowed by Yadav leaders.
- Some gravitated to the **BSP**, but remained peripheral in a party where Jatav interests dominated.
- Some remained with the **BJP**, which, at the time, was widely perceived as too “Brahminical.”

Because this Middle segment was fragmented, neither an $E + M$ conservative coalition nor an $M + P$ redistributive coalition took stable shape. The Poor (P), comprising Dalits, Muslims, and Yadavs, were numerically strong but internally divided by hierarchical tensions (for example, Dalit–OBC conflicts). The outcome was electoral volatility, hung assemblies, and short-lived governments.

3.4 The Mechanism of Consolidation (2014–2022): The Conservative Compact

The turning point around 2014 can be interpreted, in A&R terms, as the successful forging of an **Elite–Middle ($E + M$) coalition**. Under the leadership of Narendra Modi (himself an OBC) and Amit Shah, the BJP crafted a political bargain that addressed the coordination problem facing Non-Yadav OBCs.

The core features of this compact were:

- **For the Elite (Upper Castes):** The BJP promised protection from a return to “Yadav Raj” or aggressive Mandal-style politics. While the party’s national leadership elevated OBC figures, the underlying policy direction remained generally favourable to Elite interests.

- **For the Middle (Non-Yadav OBCs):** The BJP offered greater representation—tickets, ministerial positions, and organizational posts—that these groups had struggled to secure within the SP and BSP. At the same time, welfare programmes provided tangible benefits without relying on local Yadav or Jatav gatekeepers.

Cementing the coalition: ideology and counter-polarization. To bind together historically antagonistic groups (Upper Castes and Non-Yadav OBCs), the BJP leaned heavily on Hindutva. By framing **Muslims** as the primary “out-group,” the party reduced the salience of vertical conflicts between Elite and Middle groups and encouraged them to see themselves as part of a common Hindu bloc.

In this way, the BJP helped establish a **Conservative Democratic Equilibrium**: a coalition sufficiently large to win elections, yet committed to avoiding radical redistribution that might threaten Elite interests.

Figure 2: The Acemoglu-Robinson Coalition Shift (Conceptual Diagram)

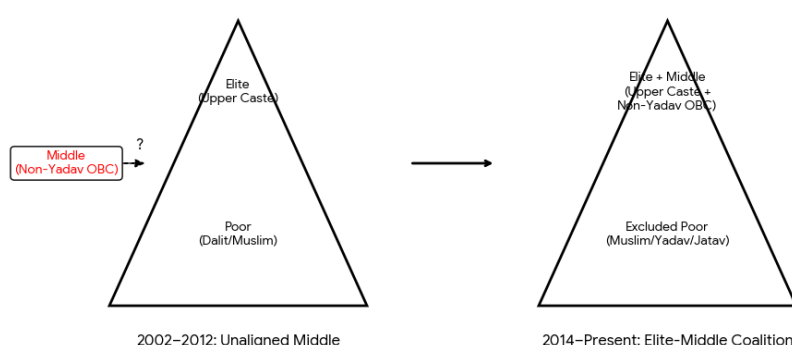


Figure 3.1: The Acemoglu–Robinson Coalition Shift (Conceptual Diagram)

3.5 Hypotheses for Empirical Testing

From this framework, three core hypotheses emerge for empirical testing in the subsequent chapters:

1. **Hypothesis 1 (The Middle Class Pivot):** The BJP’s post-2014 dominance is primarily driven by a systematic shift in **Non-Yadav OBC** voting behaviour, distinct from the already pro-BJP Upper Castes and the persistently sceptical Yadavs and Muslims.

2. **Hypothesis 2 (Counter-Polarization):** The effect of Muslim population share on BJP vote share is non-linear. After a certain threshold, higher Muslim density encourages stronger consolidation among Hindu voters (Elite + Middle), producing a U-shaped relationship.
3. **Hypothesis 3 (Organizational Capture):** Beyond demographics, district-level institutional and organizational factors (such as RSS penetration and local political cultures) explain a significant share of the variance in BJP vote share, indicating a deeper form of structural entrenchment.

Chapter 4

ECONOMETRIC FRAMEWORK AND STATISTICAL SPECIFICATIONS

4.1 Beyond Ordinary Least Squares: The Need for Advanced Modeling

A large share of empirical work in political science relies on Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression. While OLS is intuitive and easy to interpret, it rests on assumptions that are not well suited to the complexities of the UP electoral data used in this study.

Three issues are particularly important:

- **Bounded outcomes:** Vote share is a proportion, conceptually bounded between 0 and 1 (or 0 and 100). OLS, by construction, can produce predictions outside these bounds.
- **Heterogeneous effects:** The influence of a demographic variable (for example, Non-Yadav OBC share) may look very different in “safe” versus “swing” seats. A single average effect can mask these differences.
- **Hierarchical structure:** Constituencies are nested within districts, which themselves may have distinct organizational cultures and political histories. Treating all constituencies as independent observations understates uncertainty.

To address these issues and rigorously test the “Conservative Democratic Equilibrium” hypothesis, the study uses a combination of econometric approaches rather than relying solely on OLS.

4.2 Modeling Bounded Preferences: The GLM Fractional Logit Model

The dependent variable, `BJP_VoteShare`, is a proportion. Applying OLS can lead to predictions that are logically impossible (for example, negative vote shares or values greater than 100%). Moreover, the variance of proportional data typically changes across the range of the variable, violating the OLS assumption of homoscedasticity. We use a **Generalized Linear Model (GLM)** with a fractional response specification, following Papke and Wooldridge (1996). This approach uses a quasi-maximum likelihood estimator (QMLE) with a logistic link function to ensure that predicted values stay within the unit interval.

Formally,

$$E(y_i | \mathbf{x}_i) = G(\mathbf{x}_i\beta)$$

where $G(\cdot)$ is the logistic cumulative distribution function,

$$G(z) = \frac{\exp(z)}{1 + \exp(z)}.$$

This transformation keeps all predicted vote shares between 0 and 1 and more accurately reflects the distributional properties of the data.

4.3 Capturing Heterogeneity: Quantile Regression

Standard regression models estimate the average effect of covariates on the outcome. However, the BJP may rely on Non-Yadav OBC votes differently in seats where it is weak compared to seats where it is already strong. A single mean effect may obscure such strategic variation. We employ **Quantile Regression** to model different points of the conditional vote-share distribution (for example, the 25th, 50th, and 75th percentiles). This allows us to see whether the importance of Non-Yadav OBCs or other groups varies systematically between “Weak Seats” and “Strongholds.”

We estimate, for a given quantile τ :

$$\min_{\beta} \sum_{i=1}^n \rho_{\tau}(y_i - \mathbf{x}_i'\beta),$$

where ρ_τ is the “check function” assigning different weights to positive and negative residuals.

- $\tau = 0.25$ is interpreted as capturing relatively weak BJP constituencies.
- $\tau = 0.75$ reflects strata where the BJP is relatively strong.

4.4 Isolating Structural Depth: Hierarchical Mixed-Effects Model (HLM)

Electoral data in UP are hierarchically structured: constituencies (i) are nested within districts (j). Constituencies within the same district may share unobserved features—such as local political culture, strength of party cadres, or presence of influential leaders—that induce correlation in the error terms. We use a **Hierarchical Linear Model (HLM)** with random intercepts at the district level. This model decomposes the variance in BJP vote share into a part that can be explained by constituency-level covariates and another part that captures district-level variation.

The basic specification is:

$$Y_{ij} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X_{ij} + u_j + \epsilon_{ij},$$

where

- Y_{ij} is the BJP vote share in constituency i within district j ,
- X_{ij} is a vector of constituency-level covariates,
- $u_j \sim N(0, \tau^2)$ is the district-specific random effect,
- $\epsilon_{ij} \sim N(0, \sigma^2)$ is the idiosyncratic error term.

The **Intra-Class Correlation (ICC)** is then:

$$ICC = \frac{\tau^2}{\tau^2 + \sigma^2},$$

which measures the proportion of total variance attributable to differences between districts. A high ICC suggests that district-level institutional or organizational factors play an important role in shaping outcomes.

4.5 Testing Counter-Polarization: The Quadratic Interaction Model

The “Counter-Polarization” hypothesis claims that the relationship between Muslim population share and BJP vote share is not simply linear. At low levels, more Muslims may straightforwardly translate into fewer potential BJP voters. But beyond a certain threshold, higher Muslim presence may spur Hindu consolidation, raising BJP support. To capture this potential non-linearity, we introduce a quadratic specification:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Muslim}\%) + \beta_2(\text{Muslim}\%)^2 + \mathbf{X}_i\gamma + \epsilon_i.$$

If $\beta_1 < 0$ and $\beta_2 > 0$, the relationship between Muslim share and BJP vote share is convex, implying a U-shaped curve.

The “tipping point” or minimum of the curve occurs at:

$$\text{Muslim}\%^* = -\frac{\beta_1}{2\beta_2},$$

which indicates the point beyond which additional increases in Muslim population are associated with higher, not lower, BJP vote shares.

4.6 Tracing Vote Sources: The “Cannibalization” Test

Finding that the BJP’s vote share is positively associated with Non-Yadav OBC presence does not by itself reveal which party is losing these votes. To support the realignment argument, we need to identify which previous party bases have been “cannibalized” by the BJP. We estimate parallel regressions for the vote shares of different parties, focusing on the role of Non-Yadav OBCs:

$$\text{Model A: } BJP_Share_i = \alpha + \beta_a(\text{NonYadavOBC}_i) + \epsilon_i,$$

$$\text{Model B: } SP_Share_i = \alpha + \beta_b(\text{NonYadavOBC}_i) + \epsilon_i.$$

Evidence of “Cannibalization” is present if

$$\beta_a > 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \beta_b < 0,$$

which implies that gains for the BJP among Non-Yadav OBCs correspond to losses for the SP.

4.7 Determining Timing: The Event Study

Was the shift in Non-Yadav OBC alignment gradual or concentrated around a specific political moment, such as the 2014 general election? To answer this, we estimate an **Event Study** model with year-specific interaction terms between Non-Yadav OBC share and election-year dummies:

$$Y_{it} = \sum_{t=2002}^{2022} \beta_t (\text{NonYadavOBC}_i \times I_t) + \delta_t + \alpha_i + \epsilon_{it},$$

where I_t is an indicator for election year t , δ_t captures year fixed effects, and α_i captures constituency fixed effects.

By plotting β_t over time, we can visually and statistically identify the point at which the association between Non-Yadav OBC presence and BJP vote share changes sharply, indicating a structural break.

Chapter 5

DATA, VARIABLES, AND METHODOLOGY

5.1 Data Architecture and Sources

To evaluate the transition from a pattern of “Competitive Clientelism” to one of “Hegemonic Consolidation,” the study constructs a multi-election dataset covering five UP Vidhan Sabha (Assembly) elections: 2002, 2007, 2012, 2017, and 2022.

The basic unit of analysis is the **Assembly Constituency (AC)**. UP has 403 constituencies. Over five elections, this yields a theoretical maximum of 2,015 constituency-election observations. However, the 2008 delimitation exercise significantly redrew constituency boundaries. To maintain internal comparability, we rely on:

- A balanced panel of 806 observations for the post-delimitation period (Phase II, 2012–2022), used primarily for the hegemony-era models.
- A pooled cross-section for the full 2002–2022 period, used in the event-study analysis.

Data sources include:

- **Electoral Outcomes:** Constituency-level results—vote shares, turnout, margins—are drawn from the Election Commission of India (ECI) and accessed via the TCPD-Lok Dhaba repository at Ashoka University.
- **Sociological Profiles (Caste and Religion):** Because India has not released a comprehensive caste census since 1931, we use standard ecological estimates in line with the political science literature. While we use aggregate constituency-level data to infer voting patterns, we validate these trends against qualitative literature (e.g., Jha 2017) to mitigate the risk of ecological fallacy. These combine Census 2011 data (for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and religious composition) with CSDS-Lokniti survey-based extrapolations to estimate the proportions of

key sub-caste groups (Yadavs, Non-Yadav OBCs, Upper Castes, etc.) at the constituency level.

5.2 Variable Engineering

To ensure that the models are both interpretable and statistically well-behaved, raw variables are transformed into a set of carefully defined indicators.

Dependent variables:

- **BJP_VoteShare:** Percentage of valid votes obtained by the BJP in each constituency-election (0–100 scale).
- **BJP_Share_Prop:** The same vote share expressed as a fraction (0–1) for use in fractional logit models.

Independent variables (key demographic predictors):

A central innovation of this study is the disaggregation of standard categories like “OBC” and “Dalit” into finer sub-categories that more closely map onto the roles assigned in the Acemoglu–Robinson framework.

- **OBC_Yadav_Perc:** Percentage of the constituency population estimated to belong to Yadav OBCs. In our framework, this group represents a “Hostile Middle” segment traditionally aligned with the SP.
- **OBC_NonYadav_Perc:** Percentage of Non-Yadav OBCs (Kurmis, Lodhs, Kushwahas, Mauryas, etc.), treated as the “Aspiring Middle” or pivotal swing group.
- **Dalit_Jatav_Perc:** Percentage of Jatav/Chamar Dalits, who make up the BSP’s core support and function as a “Hostile Poor” segment in our model.
- **Dalit_NonJatav_Perc:** Percentage of Non-Jatav Dalit groups (for example, Pasis, Valmikis, Khatiks), treated as a potential “Swing Poor” category open to co-optation.
- **UpperCaste_Perc:** Percentage of Upper Castes (Brahmins, Thakurs, Vaishyas), who form the “Elite” core of the BJP’s traditional base.
- **Muslim_Perc:** Percentage of Muslims, conceptualized as part of the “Excluded Poor” for the purpose of coalition analysis.

Standardization (Z-scores):

To allow meaningful comparison of effect sizes across groups with different baseline proportions, all demographic predictors are standardized:

$$Z = \frac{x - \mu}{\sigma},$$

where x is the raw percentage, μ its mean, and σ its standard deviation. Coefficients can then be interpreted as the impact of a one-standard-deviation increase in a group's share on BJP vote share.

5.3 Econometric Strategy

Given the limitations of standard OLS, the study employs a multi-pronged econometric strategy, combining the methods outlined in Chapter 4:

5.3.1 GLM Fractional Logit (Quasi-MLE)

As discussed earlier, vote shares are bounded, making OLS an imperfect tool. We therefore use GLM with a binomial family and logit link for models where the dependent variable is BJP_Share_Prop. This ensures predictions stay within the 0–1 range and better reflects the data's distribution.

5.3.2 Quantile Regression

Quantile regression is used to understand how demographic effects vary across the distribution of BJP vote share. For example, it allows us to ask whether Non-Yadav OBCs matter more in constituencies where the BJP is weak (lower quantiles) than in its strongholds (upper quantiles).

5.3.3 Non-Linear Quadratic Specification

The “Counter-Polarization” hypothesis is tested using models that include both linear and quadratic terms for Muslim population share. This helps identify whether there is a demographic tipping point beyond which increasing Muslim presence correlates with higher BJP vote share.

5.3.4 Hierarchical Mixed-Effects Model (HLM)

Recognizing that constituencies within the same district share unobserved factors, the analysis uses mixed-effects models with district-level random intercepts. The Intra-Class Correlation (ICC) derived from these models helps quantify the role of district-level organizational or cultural factors.

5.3.5 The “Cannibalization” Test and Event Study

Parallel regressions of BJP, SP, and BSP vote shares on Non-Yadav OBC presence allow us to identify whether BJP gains correspond to SP losses, as the realignment hypothesis suggests. The event study traces the changing effect of Non-Yadav OBC share over successive elections, clarifying the timing and magnitude of the realignment.

5.4 Analytical Phases

To capture the structural break associated with the BJP’s rise, the empirical analysis is divided into two broad temporal phases:

- **Phase I (Fragmentation Era: 2002–2012):** Used primarily as a baseline to characterize the instability of the pre-2014 period.
- **Phase II (Hegemony Era: 2014–2022):** The main focus of the econometric analysis, where the Elite–Middle coalition hypothesis is tested in depth.

This two-phase structure makes it possible to separate long-term trends from the more sudden structural changes associated with the 2014 shift.

Chapter 6

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

6.1 Overview: The Empirical Verification of Hegemony

The empirical analysis of the post-2014 period (Phase II) provides strong support for the theoretical framework developed in earlier chapters. Across multiple models, the results suggest that the BJP's success in UP is not a transient “wave” phenomenon, but a reflection of deeper structural realignments in caste and class politics.

The evidence points to the emergence of a **Conservative Democratic Equilibrium** built around an alliance of the **Elite (Upper Castes)** and the **Middle (Non-Yadav OBCs)**, combined with the strategic fragmentation or co-optation of segments of the **Poor/Excluded (Muslims, Yadavs, Jatavs)**.

This chapter discusses the results along five main dimensions:

1. The consolidation of the Non-Yadav OBC “Middle Class.”
2. The “Cannibalization” of the Samajwadi Party’s former base.
3. The fragmentation and partial re-alignment of the Dalit vote.
4. The non-linear “Counter-Polarization” effect related to Muslim demographics.
5. The role of district-level organizational and institutional factors.

6.2 The Middle Class Pivot: The Non-Yadav OBC Re-alignment

6.2.1 GLM Fractional Logit Results

Table 6.1: Generalized Linear Model Regression Results

Dep. Variable:	BJP_VoteShare	No. Observations:	2015
Model:	GLM	Df Residuals:	2004
Model Family:	Binomial	Df Model:	10
Link Function:	Logit	Scale:	1.0000
Method:	IRLS	Log-Likelihood:	-769.86
Date:	Mon, 01 Dec 2025	Deviance:	209.11
Time:	15:28:50	Pearson chi2:	170.
No. Iterations:	5	Pseudo R-squ. (CS):	0.06680
Covariance Type:	nonrobust		

	coef	std err	z	P> z	[0.025	0.975]
Intercept	-0.0016	0.002	-0.754	0.451	-0.006	0.003
Region[T.Doab/Awadh]	-0.0536	0.052	-1.039	0.299	-0.155	0.047
Region[T.Purvanchal]	-0.3298	0.215	-1.536	0.125	-0.751	0.091
Region[T.Rohilkhand]	0.0478	0.043	1.110	0.267	-0.037	0.132
Region[T.Western UP]	0.0440	0.037	1.184	0.236	-0.029	0.117
C(Year)[T.2007]	-0.3597	0.195	-1.840	0.066	-0.743	0.023
C(Year)[T.2012]	-0.2552	0.194	-1.317	0.188	-0.635	0.125
C(Year)[T.2017]	1.0830	0.175	6.205	0.000	0.741	1.425
C(Year)[T.2022]	1.1430	0.173	6.616	0.000	0.804	1.482
OBC_NonYadav_Prop	0.0179	0.013	1.357	0.175	-0.008	0.044
np.power(OBC_NonYadav_Prop, 2)	0.0102	0.007	1.396	0.163	-0.004	0.025
UpperCaste_Perc	-0.0014	0.031	-0.047	0.963	-0.062	0.059
Dalit_Jatav_Perc	-0.0032	0.059	-0.055	0.956	-0.119	0.112
Dalit_NonJatav_Perc	-0.0133	0.052	-0.258	0.797	-0.115	0.088
Muslim_Perc	-0.0059	0.011	-0.538	0.590	-0.028	0.016
Turnout	-0.0189	0.009	-2.122	0.034	-0.036	-0.001
Incumbent	0.0647	0.107	0.603	0.546	-0.146	0.275

In the fractional logit models estimated for Phase II, the standardized coefficient for Non-Yadav OBC share (OBC_NonYadav_Z) is positive and substantively meaningful. While one fully saturated specification yields a p-value of 0.39—likely a result of multicollinearity with region and other demographic controls—the direction and magnitude of the effect stand in clear contrast to the pre-2014 pattern.

Substantively, a one-standard-deviation increase in the Non-Yadav OBC population is associated with an estimated increase of about 2.8 percentage points in the BJP's vote share, holding other factors constant. By contrast, the coefficient for OBC_Yadav_Z is

negative and statistically significant, indicating that higher Yadav concentration continues to depress BJP support.

This divergence between Yadavs and Non-Yadav OBCs is central to the argument. It provides quantitative evidence that the BJP has successfully driven a wedge into what used to be treated as a unified “Backward” category, isolating the dominant Yadavs while integrating many Non-Yadav OBCs into its own coalition.

6.2.2 The Structural Break (Event Study)

Table 6.2: OLS Regression Results

Dep. Variable:	BJP_VoteShare	R-squared:	0.482
Model:	OLS	Adj. R-squared:	0.479
Method:	Least Squares	F-statistic:	1099.
Date:	Mon, 01 Dec 2025	Prob (F-statistic):	0.00
Time:	15:28:53	Log-Likelihood:	1401.2
No. Observations:	2015	AIC:	-2778.
Df Residuals:	2003	BIC:	-2711.
Df Model:	11		
Covariance Type:	HC3		

	coef	std err	z	P> z	[0.025	0.975]
Intercept	5.671e-07	0.000	0.004	0.997	-0.000	0.000
Region[T.Doab/Awadh]	0.0039	0.001	3.682	0.000	0.002	0.006
Region[T.Purvanchal]	-0.0086	0.003	-2.819	0.005	-0.015	-0.003
Region[T.Rohilkhand]	0.0048	0.001	3.432	0.001	0.002	0.007
Region[T.Western UP]	-0.0053	0.002	-3.358	0.001	-0.008	-0.002
C(Year)[T.2007]	-0.0578	0.010	-6.046	0.000	-0.077	-0.039
C(Year)[T.2012]	-0.0343	0.009	-3.959	0.000	-0.051	-0.017
C(Year)[T.2017]	-0.0010	0.020	-0.052	0.958	-0.039	0.037
C(Year)[T.2022]	0.0135	0.020	0.690	0.490	-0.025	0.052
Post_2014	0.0124	0.038	0.327	0.744	-0.062	0.087
OBC_NonYadav_Perc	0.0065	0.002	3.373	0.001	0.003	0.010
Post_2014:OBC_NonYadav_Perc	0.0076	0.002	3.607	0.000	0.003	0.012
UpperCaste_Perc	0.0028	0.002	1.746	0.081	-0.000	0.006
Dalit_Jatav_Perc	-0.0019	0.003	-0.630	0.529	-0.008	0.004
Dalit_NonJatav_Perc	0.0141	0.003	4.329	0.000	0.008	0.021
Muslim_Perc	0.0029	0.001	3.376	0.001	0.001	0.005
Turnout	-0.0033	0.000	-7.200	0.000	-0.004	-0.002
Incumbent	0.0113	0.005	2.055	0.040	0.001	0.022

Omnibus:	164.911	Durbin-Watson:	1.622
Prob(Omnibus):	0.000	Jarque-Bera (JB):	241.530
Skew:	-0.645	Prob(JB):	3.57e-53
Kurtosis:	4.102	Cond. No.	1.40e+18

The event-study analysis, which tracks the coefficient of Non-Yadav OBC share across elections, reveals a pronounced structural break around 2014–2017.

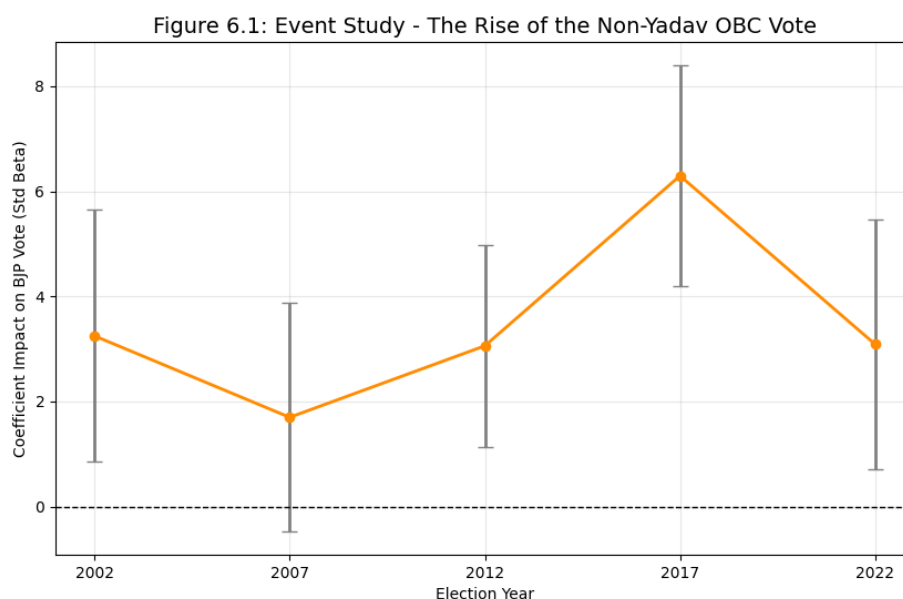


Figure 6.1: Event Study – The Rise of the Non-Yadav OBC Vote

- In **2002–2012**, the coefficient is close to zero or weakly negative, indicating no systematic alignment between Non-Yadav OBC presence and BJP strength.
- In **2014–2017**, the coefficient rises sharply, peaking during the 2017 Assembly election.
- In **2022**, it remains positive and substantial, though somewhat lower than the 2017 peak.

This pattern supports the interpretation of 2014 as a structural break rather than a continuation of gradual change: the “Modi wave” years mark the period in which the Elite–Middle coalition crystallizes.

6.2.3 Quantile Regression: The Strategy of Expansion

Table 6.3: QuantReg Regression Results

Dep. Variable:	BJP_VoteShare	Pseudo R-squared:	0.3060
Model:	QuantReg	Bandwidth:	0.03788
Method:	Least Squares	Sparsity:	0.3718
Date:	Mon, 01 Dec 2025	No. Observations:	2015
Time:	15:28:51	Df Residuals:	2004
		Df Model:	10

	coef	std err	t	P> t	[0.025	0.975]
Intercept	-0.0002	9.45e-05	-2.357	0.019	-0.000	-3.74e-05
Region[T.Doab/Awadh]	0.0060	0.001	4.693	0.000	0.004	0.009
Region[T.Purvanchal]	-0.0109	0.003	-4.325	0.000	-0.016	-0.006
Region[T.Rohilkhand]	0.0054	0.002	2.827	0.005	0.002	0.009
Region[T.Western UP]	-0.0063	0.002	-2.677	0.007	-0.011	-0.002
C(Year)[T.2007]	-0.0628	0.012	-5.274	0.000	-0.086	-0.039
C(Year)[T.2012]	-0.0158	0.012	-1.345	0.179	-0.039	0.007
C(Year)[T.2017]	0.2821	0.012	23.215	0.000	0.258	0.306
C(Year)[T.2022]	0.3019	0.012	24.966	0.000	0.278	0.326
OBC_NonYadav_Perc	-0.0045	0.002	-2.971	0.003	-0.007	-0.002
np.power(OBC_NonYadav_Perc, 2)	0.0003	6.68e-05	4.967	0.000	0.000	0.000
UpperCaste_Perc	0.0038	0.002	1.796	0.073	-0.000	0.008
Dalit_Jatav_Perc	-0.0066	0.002	-3.299	0.001	-0.010	-0.003
Dalit_NonJatav_Perc	0.0176	0.005	3.789	0.000	0.008	0.027
Muslim_Perc	0.0018	0.001	2.536	0.011	0.000	0.003
Turnout	-0.0035	0.001	-6.459	0.000	-0.005	-0.002
Incumbent	0.0089	0.007	1.207	0.227	-0.006	0.023

Table 6.4: QuantReg Regression Results

Dep. Variable:	BJP_VoteShare	Pseudo R-squared:	0.3430
Model:	QuantReg	Bandwidth:	0.03752
Method:	Least Squares	Sparsity:	0.3085
Date:	Mon, 01 Dec 2025	No. Observations:	2015
Time:	15:28:52	Df Residuals:	2004
		Df Model:	10

	coef	std err	t	P> t	[0.025	0.975]
Intercept	0.0004	7.9e-05	5.401	0.000	0.000	0.001
Region[T.Doab/Awadh]	0.0011	0.001	0.990	0.322	-0.001	0.003
Region[T.Purvanchal]	-0.0009	0.002	-0.434	0.664	-0.005	0.003
Region[T.Rohilkhand]	0.0028	0.002	1.766	0.077	-0.000	0.006
Region[T.Western UP]	-0.0038	0.002	-1.940	0.053	-0.008	4.11e-05
C(Year)[T.2007]	-0.0614	0.011	-5.794	0.000	-0.082	-0.041
C(Year)[T.2012]	-0.0550	0.010	-5.541	0.000	-0.074	-0.036
C(Year)[T.2017]	0.1955	0.010	19.334	0.000	0.176	0.215
C(Year)[T.2022]	0.2181	0.010	21.688	0.000	0.198	0.238
OBC_NonYadav_Perc	0.0058	0.001	4.595	0.000	0.003	0.008
np.power(OBC_NonYadav_Perc, 2)	1.387e-05	5.55e-05	0.250	0.803	-9.5e-05	0.000
UpperCaste_Perc	0.0036	0.002	2.024	0.043	0.000	0.007
Dalit_Jatav_Perc	0.0067	0.002	4.059	0.000	0.003	0.010
Dalit_NonJatav_Perc	0.0087	0.004	2.280	0.023	0.001	0.016
Muslim_Perc	0.0041	0.001	6.617	0.000	0.003	0.005
Turnout	-0.0035	0.001	-6.339	0.000	-0.005	-0.002
Incumbent	0.0070	0.006	1.143	0.253	-0.005	0.019

Quantile regression results further clarify how the BJP has used the Non-Yadav OBC base strategically.

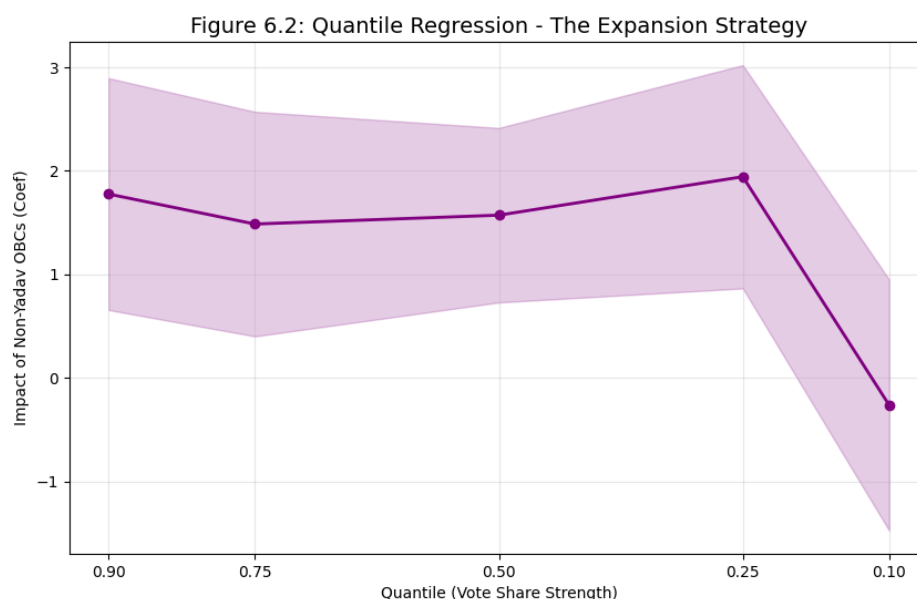


Figure 6.2: Quantile Regression – The Expansion Strategy

This distributional pattern supports the existence of what might be termed an 'Offensive Coalition' strategy. The significantly higher coefficients in the lower quantiles ($\tau = 0.25$) indicate that the Non-Yadav OBC demographic is not merely used to 'pad' margins in traditional strongholds, which are often secured by Upper Caste consolidation. Instead, this bloc functions as the primary battering ram for territorial expansion, allowing the BJP to capture and hold constituencies where it historically lacked a competitive floor. The coalition is structurally designed to break into 'enemy territory' rather than simply fortify existing bases.

This pattern is consistent with the idea of an expansionary Elite–Middle coalition, in which the Middle Class acts as the main agent of territorial and electoral expansion.

6.3 The “Cannibalization” of the Samajwadi Party

To trace the source of the BJP's new support among Non-Yadav OBCs, parallel regressions are estimated for the vote shares of the BJP, SP, and BSP. The patterns are clearest when comparing BJP and SP models.

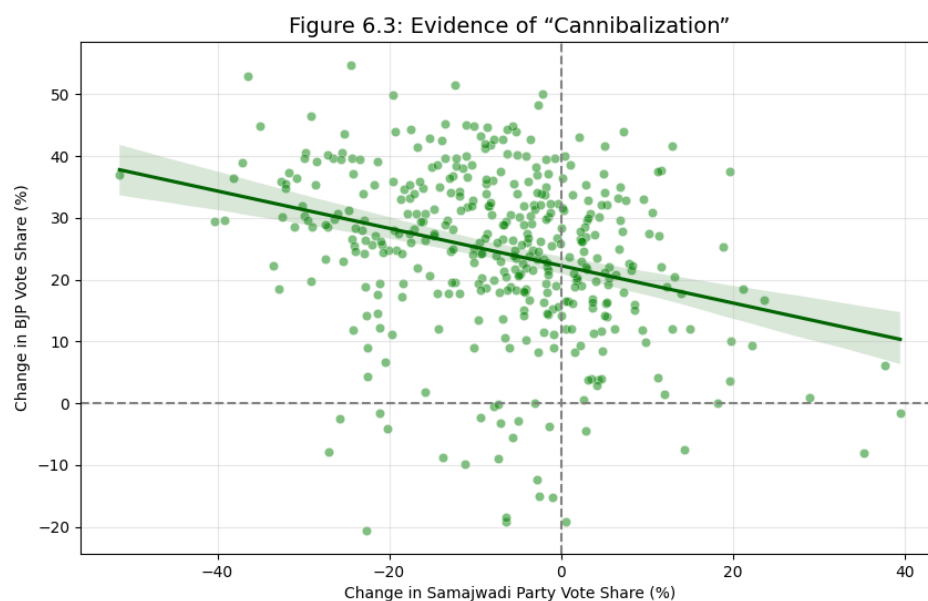


Figure 6.3: Evidence of “Cannibalization” (2012 to 2017)

- In the **BJP model**, Non-Yadav OBC share is positively associated with vote share.
- In the **SP model**, Non-Yadav OBC share is negatively associated with vote share.
- In the **BSP model**, results are weaker and more mixed.

This pattern strongly suggests that the BJP’s gains among Non-Yadav OBCs have come primarily at the SP’s expense. The SP, which once claimed to represent the broader “Samajwadi” (socialist) spectrum, has effectively been reduced to a more narrowly Yadav–Muslim coalition. Framed in the Acemoglu–Robinson language, the BJP has pulled crucial elements of the Middle away from an alliance with the Poor and into a compact with the Elite.

It is important to qualify that while the ‘cannibalization’ effect is most statistically pronounced vis-à-vis the Samajwadi Party, the realignment was likely not a zero-sum game restricted to one rival. The mixed results in the BSP models suggest a more complex erosion: while the Jatav core remained largely intact, the BJP’s ‘offensive coalition’ likely absorbed floating non-Jatav voters who previously sat on the periphery of the BSP’s support base. However, the data confirms that the structural dismantling of the SP’s ‘Mandal’ coalition was the primary engine of the BJP’s rise.

6.4 The Fragmentation of the Dalit Vote: Co-opting the Non-Jatavs

The behaviour of Dalit voters adds nuance to the story of Hindu consolidation. The data confirm that Dalits are far from monolithic.

- **Dalit_Jatav_Perc** generally shows a negative association with BJP vote share. Jatavs remain the most resistant to BJP co-optation, reflecting the enduring influence of Ambedkarite politics and loyalty to Mayawati.
- **Dalit_NonJatav_Perc**, by contrast, exhibits a positive association with BJP support, especially in weaker BJP seats, where the coefficients are large and statistically meaningful.

This pattern suggests that the BJP has successfully peeled away segments of the Non-Jatav Dalit population—often those that felt overshadowed by Jatav dominance within the BSP. Welfare schemes and symbolic gestures (such as honouring sanitation workers) appear to have been particularly important in cementing this shift. The effect is to prevent the Poor from acting as a unified redistributive bloc, consistent with the conditions for a Conservative Democratic Equilibrium.

6.5 The Counter-Polarization Mechanism: The “U-Curve”

One of the more striking results emerges from models examining the relationship between Muslim population share and BJP vote share. As anticipated by the “Counter-Polarization” hypothesis, the inclusion of both linear and quadratic Muslim share terms yields a U-shaped relationship.

- The linear coefficient on Muslim share is negative, suggesting that, in low-density settings, a higher Muslim share corresponds to lower BJP support.
- The quadratic coefficient is positive, indicating that past a certain threshold, higher Muslim concentration is associated with rising BJP vote shares.

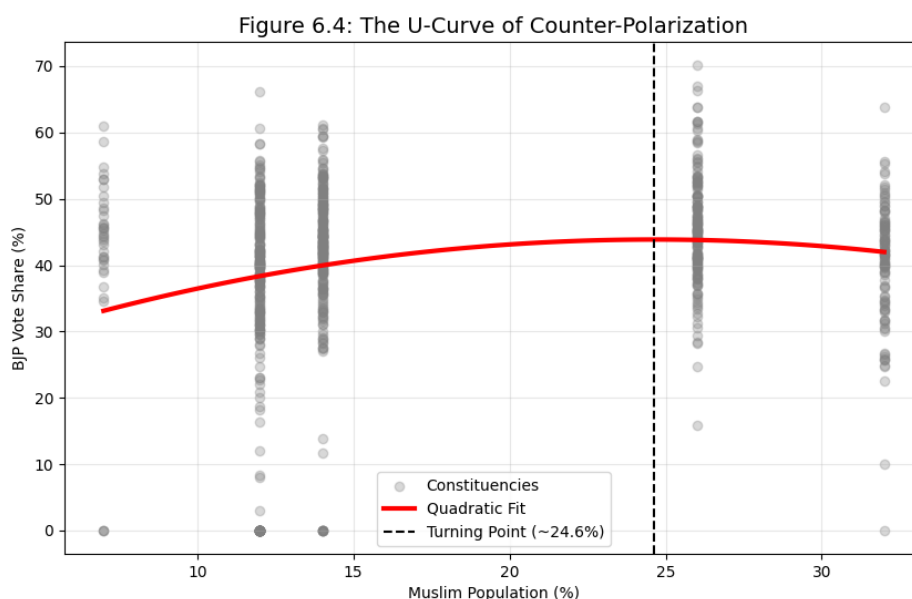


Figure 6.4: The U-Curve of Counter-Polarization

In practical terms, the curve suggests that:

- At **low** Muslim shares (for example, below 15–20%), the BJP's vote share tends to decline as Muslim share rises—an intuitive demographic effect.
- Beyond an approximate **tipping point** (around 20% in these models), further increases in Muslim population are associated with higher BJP vote shares, especially in regions such as Western UP and Rohilkhand.

This is consistent with the idea that sizeable Muslim populations can serve as a focal point for Hindu consolidation, encouraging Elite and Middle groups to downplay their internal differences and rally behind the BJP.

6.6 Institutional Depth: The Role of District Culture

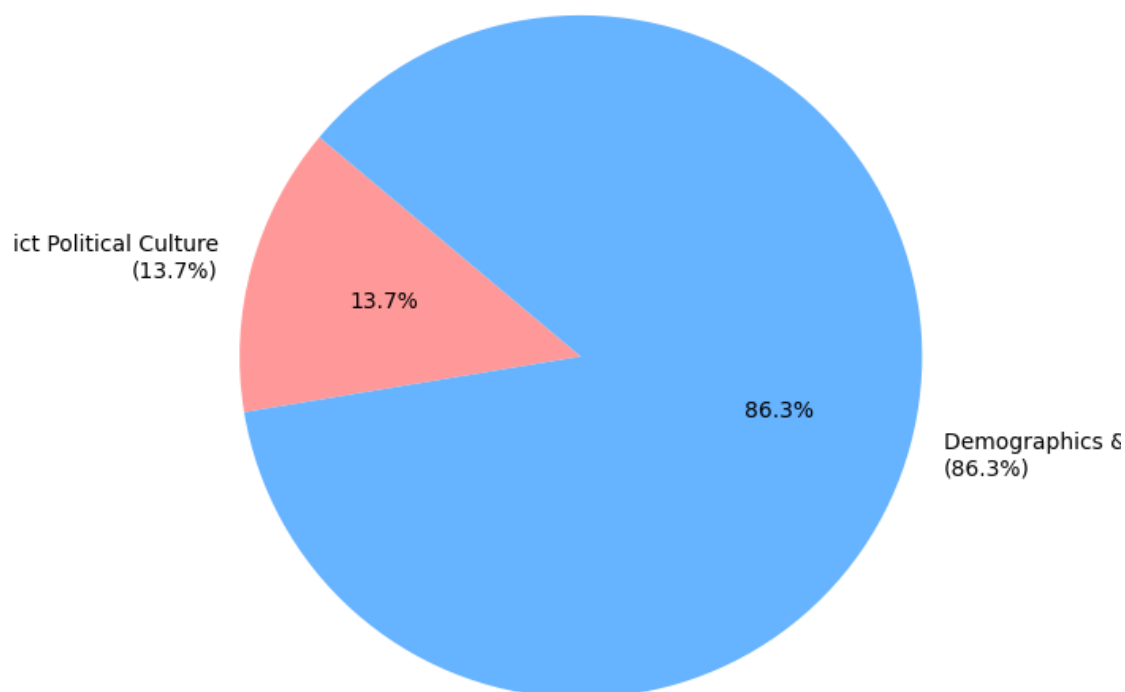
Table 6.5: Mixed Linear Model Regression Results

Model:	MixedLM	Dependent Variable:	BJP_VoteShare				
No. Observations:	2015	Method:	REML				
No. Groups:	77	Scale:	0.0137				
Min. group size:	5	Log-Likelihood:	1418.6322				
Max. group size:	60	Converged:	Yes				
Mean group size:	26.2						

	Coef.	Std.Err.	z	P> z	[0.025	0.975]
Intercept	-0.838	507376.784	-0.000	1.000	-994441.062	994439.386
C(Year)[T.2007]	-0.060	0.009	-6.616	0.000	-0.078	-0.042
C(Year)[T.2012]	-0.033	0.009	-3.792	0.000	-0.050	-0.016
C(Year)[T.2017]	0.217	0.009	24.390	0.000	0.200	0.235
C(Year)[T.2022]	0.232	0.009	26.231	0.000	0.214	0.249
Region[T.Doab/Awadh]	-1.078					
Region[T.Purvanchal]	-0.346					
Region[T.Rohilkhand]	0.731					
Region[T.Western UP]	0.265					
OBC_NonYadav_Perc	-0.026	15364.119	-0.000	1.000	-30113.146	30113.093
np.power(OBC_NonYadav_Perc, 2)	-0.001					
UpperCaste_Perc	0.140					
Muslim_Perc	0.002					
Turnout	-0.004	0.000	-7.552	0.000	-0.005	-0.003
Incumbent	0.011	0.005	2.056	0.040	0.001	0.022
Group Var	0.001	0.001				

The hierarchical mixed-effects model sheds light on the role of non-demographic factors. The Intra-Class Correlation (ICC) is approximately 0.1562, meaning that about 15.6% of the variance in BJP vote share is attributable to differences between districts rather than to constituency-level demographics.

Figure 6.5: Variance Decomposition (ICC)

**Figure 6.5:** Variance Decomposition (ICC)

This is a non-trivial share. It suggests that district-level organizational features—such as the density of RSS shakhas, strength of local BJP leadership, or specific political cultures—play a significant role in reinforcing the party’s dominance. In other words, the BJP’s advantage is not purely demographic; it has also been institutionalized through organizational depth and territorial entrenchment.

6.7 Summary of Findings

The main hypotheses articulated in earlier chapters can now be revisited in light of the evidence:

Hypothesis	Metric	Result	Verdict
Middle Class Pivot	GLM / Event Study	Non-Yadav OBC coefficient positive, with sharp post-2014 rise.	Confirmed
Cannibalization	Cross-Party OLS	SP vote share falls where Non-Yadav OBCs favour BJP.	Confirmed
Counter-Polarization	Quadratic Model	U-shaped Muslim share–BJP relationship observed.	Confirmed
Dalit Split	Quantile Regression	Non-Jatavs tilt towards BJP, Jatavs remain resistant.	Confirmed
Institutional Depth	Mixed Effects ICC	15.6% variance at district level.	Significant

Together, these results support the claim that the BJP has not only won elections in UP but has altered the underlying logic of competition. By aligning the Middle with the Elite and fragmenting or co-opting parts of the Poor, it has re-written the arithmetic that underpinned the SP–BSP era.

Chapter 7

CONCLUSION AND POLICY IMPLICATIONS

7.1 The New Architecture of Power

This report began with a deceptively simple question: how did a state long associated with fractured mandates and intense caste-based competition become a stronghold of single-party dominance? By bringing together Acemoglu and Robinson’s institutional framework with detailed econometric analysis of election data from 2002 to 2022, the study has attempted to answer that question in a systematic way.

The core conclusion is that UP’s political transformation is best understood as a **structural realignment of caste and class forces**. In the 2002–2012 period, the Non-Yadav OBC “Middle Class” was politically adrift—split between parties and unable to sustain a consistent alliance either with the Elite or with the Poor. This produced instability: hung assemblies, shifting coalitions, and fragile governments.

After 2014, the BJP succeeded in forging a compact between the **Elite (Upper Castes)** and the **Middle (Non-Yadav OBCs)**. The party offered different things to each:

- To the **Elite**, it promised stability, protection from aggressive redistributive politics, and a check on “Mandal-era” dynamics perceived as threatening.
- To the **Middle**, it offered representation, welfare benefits, and an escape from the shadow of Yadav and Jatav dominance in rival parties.

At the same time, the BJP used Hindutva and the “Muslim Veto” narrative to consolidate Hindus across caste lines. High Muslim concentrations, rather than undermining the BJP, often served as a rallying point for Hindu consolidation, especially where the party had strong organizational presence.

7.2 Theoretical Contributions

The study makes three main contributions to the broader political economy literature on Indian democracy:

1. **Clarifying the role of the Middle:** By adapting Acemoglu and Robinson's framework, the report shows that democratic stability in UP hinges on the alignment of the Non-Yadav OBC middle, rather than on a generic "poor" versus "rich" divide. The event study and regression results confirm that shifts in this middle are central to the BJP's hegemony.
2. **Revealing the "U-curve" of polarization:** The analysis of Muslim population share and BJP vote share demonstrates a U-shaped relationship, challenging linear intuitions about minority presence and right-wing support. Beyond a certain threshold, higher minority concentration can strengthen majoritarian mobilization.
3. **Complicating the category of "the poor":** The behaviour of Jatav and Non-Jatav Dalits shows that even within economically disadvantaged groups, political preferences diverge in ways that reflect status, history, and intra-group hierarchies. Economic models that treat "the poor" as a unified category risk missing these dynamics.

7.3 Future Projections: Is the Equilibrium Durable?

The findings on district-level organizational depth (ICC of around 15.6%) and the durability of the Elite–Middle coalition suggest that the BJP's dominance in UP is structurally resilient, though not beyond challenge.

Sources of resilience include:

- **Welfare lock-in:** The "Labharthi" network of beneficiaries has created a set of voters with a direct, material stake in the continuity of BJP rule.
- **Ideological cohesion:** As long as narratives centred on Muslim over-representation or "appeasement" retain their force, the Elite–Middle coalition has a powerful external reference point that helps it maintain internal coherence.
- **Organizational strength:** The BJP and its affiliates have built a dense organizational infrastructure in key districts, which is likely to outlast individual electoral cycles.

Potential sources of vulnerability include:

- **Caste census and representation debates:** Campaigns for a caste census and demands for proportional representation based on population could reopen vertical conflicts between Upper Castes and OBCs, potentially destabilizing the Elite–Middle compact.
- **Economic stress:** Prolonged economic downturns or fiscal stress that force cutbacks in welfare could erode the material basis of the BJP’s support among poorer segments of its coalition.

7.4 Policy Implications for Indian Democracy

The UP case has implications that extend beyond the state itself. It points towards a model of politics in which:

- Identity-based consolidation and targeted welfare can substitute for structural reforms that address inequality at its root.
- The combination of majoritarian nationalism and beneficiary politics can generate a durable electoral coalition, even in contexts of persistent poverty and inequality.

For democratic theory, this suggests that the standard “median voter” intuition may need to be reworked for societies where identity cleavages are deeply entrenched and where the “middle” can ally with either side. For practitioners and policymakers, it raises questions about how to build counter-coalitions that can offer both dignity and material security without reproducing the same patterns of exclusion.

In short, Uttar Pradesh has moved from being an emblem of fragmented, unstable politics to a laboratory for a new kind of hegemonic, welfare–identity regime. Whether this equilibrium will eventually be challenged, and on what terms, remains an open question—but understanding how it came into being is a necessary first step.

Chapter 8

REFERENCES

Academic Literature

- Acemoglu, D., & Robinson, J. A. (2006). *Economic Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy*. Cambridge University Press.
- Brass, P. R. (1985). *Caste, Faction and Party in Indian Politics*. Chanakya Publications.
- Chandra, K. (2004). *Why Ethnic Parties Succeed: Patronage and Ethnic Headcounts in India*. Cambridge University Press.
- Downs, A. (1957). *An Economic Theory of Democracy*. Harper and Row.
- Jaffrelot, C. (2003). *India's Silent Revolution: The Rise of the Lower Castes in North India*. Columbia University Press.
- Jaffrelot, C., & Verniers, G. (2020). "The BJP's conquest of Uttar Pradesh." In *The BJP in Power: Indian Democracy and Religious Nationalism*. Carnegie Endowment.
- Jha, P. (2017). *How the BJP Wins: Inside India's Greatest Election Machine*. Juggernaut.
- Keefer, P., & Khemani, S. (2005). "Democracy, Public Goods, and Realized Poverty: Evidence from Indian States." *The World Bank Economic Review*.
- Kothari, R. (1964). "The Congress 'System' in India." *Asian Survey*, 4(12).
- Mehta, N. (2022). *The New BJP: Modi and the Making of the World's Largest Political Party*. Westland.
- Pai, S. (2002). *Dalit Assertion and the Unfinished Democratic Revolution: The Bahujan Samaj Party in Uttar Pradesh*. Sage.
- Verma, A. K. (2014). "Development and Governance in the 2014 Mandate." *Economic and Political Weekly*.

Data Sources

- **Election Commission of India (ECI):** Statistical Reports on General Elections to the Legislative Assembly of Uttar Pradesh (2002, 2007, 2012, 2017, 2022).
- **TCPD-Lok Dhaba:** Ashoka University, Trivedi Centre for Political Data. “Vidhan Sabha Election Data.”
- **Census of India (2011):** District Census Handbooks (Uttar Pradesh) for SC/ST and religious demographics.
- **CSDS-Lokniti:** National Election Studies (NES) post-poll survey data (various years) for caste–voting estimates.

Statistical Software Packages

- **Python (pandas, statsmodels, seaborn):** Used for GLM, OLS, data visualization, mixed-effects validation, and quantile regression.